Always You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43275393.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Scorpia's Mothers (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Trans Catra (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Soulmates, Soulmates, Friends to Lovers, Best Friends, Growing Up Together, Angst, Fluff and Angst, Love Confessions, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-26 Words: 6,087 Chapters: 1/1

Always You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43275393.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Scorpia's Mothers (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Trans Catra (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Soulmates, Soulmates, Friends to Lovers, Best Friends, Growing Up Together, Angst, Fluff and Angst, Love Confessions, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-26 Words: 6,087 Chapters: 1/1

Always You

by ResFlower

Summary

She runs a hand down her best friend’s side, taking advantage of the way her shirt rode up to pet her there. Suddenly, Cat tenses, her tail fluffing up in a way that used to tell Adora she might get clawed. She looks down at Cat warily.

"No, you just you touched it." She says gently, eyes darting away in embarrassment.

Adora drops her hand as if she's been burned. She doesn't need her to elaborate further to know what she's stumbled on. The name of whatever lucky girl will get to call Cat hers forever. She bites her lip to keep from asking if she'd ever thought about the name Catra.

Every time Cat tried a new name it felt like it was getting closer and closer Cassidy, Caitlin, Katherine and her heart dropped every time Cat tried on another name that wasn't the one embossed on her shoulder.

OR

Catra and Adora have known their soulmate's name since they are sixteen. If only the names matched who they felt they belonged to. Soulmate AU from a trans perspective.

Notes

Thank you to yagirlStatic for the prompt and editing help. Y'all should check out her new fic!

Hope you enjoy :)

See the end of the work for more notes

He's been on pins and needles all day today. It's stressful because not only did he want to make sure Adora had a good birthday, but it's also her sixteenth. She's the first of the two of them to discover her soulmate's name and he can't help but wonder who it might be.

They managed to go to the skating rink behind Weaver's back, and when they got back home Adora quietly went to the bathroom. He just knows she's looking for her soulmate's name.

His heart thumps unevenly as it always does when he thinks of Adora these days. Everyone keeps talking about how all their hormones are changing but he doesn't think it's that.

His body *has* been changing though and it's been terrible. A lot of the fur on his sides has grown thicker and he's grown taller and leaner, losing some of his childhood roundness. He'd always been different—magicats weren't common here in Bright Moon—but this is somehow worse than that otherness that he's become acquainted with.

When Adora comes out of the bathroom she lays down on her bed. She barely makes eye contact with him as she does so, whatever happiness they had earlier in the day displaced.

"So? You aren't going to share?" He says jokingly, hoping it'll make Adora open up some or at least make her smile.

"I don't know." Her voice is subdued and sad as she turns in her bed.

He sits on the ground, head propped up on the mattress. He hadn't laid next to Adora in over a year, the last time he had Weaver had almost kicked him out, accusing him of taking advantage somehow. She'd called him an animal and it had taken weeks of soft assurances from Adora for him to think that maybe Weaver isn't right on that point.

"Why not?" Part of him wishes that it's because Adora might have his name on her body, something that shows that the feelings he has for her aren't one-sided. He's always loved Adora, ever since he first came to Weaver's house, and she reached her hand out, pet his ears, and asked if he wanted to play.

Her voice drops into a whisper. "I don't understand it. I'm scared." She admits finally.

He feels his heart stop. "What do you mean 'Or'?" He hates how his voice drops low when he asks the question.

"You know how Weaver says that being gay is..." She cuts off sucking in a deep breath.

His hand freezes on the edge of the mattress, things falling into place. "Your... soulmate isn't a dude, is it?"

Adora's eyes snap up at him and the fear there knocks the breath out of his lungs. He reaches out and grabs her hand, not caring if Weaver walks in and sees.

"Adora." He says firmly. "Whoever you love or whoever your soulmate is, it doesn't make you a bad person." Adora is loyal and strong, beautiful inside and out. Hell be damned if he doesnt remind her of that.

"But she said- you know what she says..." she's hiccupping now, tears streaming down her face.

He clambers onto the bed, holding her close. "She's full of shit." He says plainly. "Besides, just because your soulmate is a girl, doesn't mean you're...you know." He whispers finally.

Soulmates can mean a lot of things, or so their high school teachers have said. It's the wrong thing to say because Adora only cries harder at that.

"But Ithink Ithink Iam. Idon't think Ilike boys that way ."She finally admits.

His heart plummets in his chest but he runs a soothing hand down her back, making sure to keep his claws retracted. He wraps his tail around her too, knowing she likes that.

"That's alright 'Dor . You can love who you want."He says again, heart breaking with the knowledge that it'll never be him.

t's no surprise that Adora cant possibly be meant for him when he can barely stomach the sight of himself.

So much happens between Adora's sixteenth and his. T o start, he gets taken in by a family when everyone least expects it.

The Dreams are good people and after six months, he thinks they've convinced him that maybe they won't toss him out at the smallest provocation. He still stays on his best behavior, not wanting to tempt fate, but it's nothing like the militaristic living situation he'd grown accustomed to.

t' s his first birthday not living with Adora and he wakes up a little homesick. Not for Weaver's but for Adora's company. t's Saturday and Adora's new foster mother probably won't let her come over until later in the day.

When he goes down for breakfast, he finds Scorpia making pancakes while their parents put together other things in the kitchen.

He freezes heart thumping in his chest as he realizes that this might be for him. *For his birthday*. But he can't assume that there are lots of Saturdays when they eat something that he'd consider special. Maybe it's just one of those days.

He is dissuaded from the notion when he sees how the three women light up when they see him. "Happy birthday!"They all call out as if

rehearsed.

He grins, kind of disbelieving that he gets to have this today. All the breakfast food gets tossed onto plates and they all gather around the table.

"I love having a little brother! It's great." Scorpia says cheerily and something in his stomach drops. "I really like that we get to celebrate such a special birthday with you! I remember mine like it was just yesterday."

"It was last year Scorp." He reminds gently. "You're barely a year older than me."

"I know but it's an exciting day! Have you tried to check for it yet?" She asks eagerly as she leans on her arm. Scorpia might only be a year older but she's a hell of a lot taller than him. He likes that about her.

"Scorpia, that's not an appropriate question." Linda admonishes while buttering her toast. "Soulmates are a private thing and we should respect everyone's decision on how to approach it."

"It's alright." He allows, knowing that Scorpia doesnt mean any harm. "I haven't checked yet, figured it would be better later."

Scorpia nods. "Yeah, that makes sense."

They finish breakfast and then all watch a movie together and he feels like a part of him clicks into place with this family that has shown him unrelenting kindness.

After the movie, he is determined to look for his soulmate's name. He doesn't feel anything different, and he's kind of nervous. He knows that his soulmate's name appears as if by magic sometime during his birthday. What if he checks too early and can't find it?

He gathers up the courage and goes to the bathroom. His hands and face are bare which is a small relief~~it's~~ one thing to have a soulmate another to walk around with a name imprinted on your face.

He slowly tugs on his sweater, pulling it up and checking his back. As he turns, he thinks he catches something obscured in the fur on his right side. He moves the fur looking at the skin beneath. His heart thumps unevenly and his hands tremble as he tries to decipher the letters.

It's like a stab in the heart once the letters become clear .

Adora

He should have known. Or really, he supposes he knew deep down. It's not surprising really~~he~~'s always been in Adora's orbit, a hapless sunflower stretching toward a sun too bright and far away to reach.

He sinks down, his back pressed against the wall as he hunches over. With one hand pressed over the blonde's name on his ribs, he lets himself cry for the mere fact that the universe damn well recognizes that he could only belong to her , but she'd never be his.

It's a few days before Halloween when he finally admits it to himself. He's supposed to go to a costume party for his senior year, but it all feels wrong.

Adora suggested a million and one costumes that they could wear together. Although the idea of matching with Adora makes his heart flutter, the more he looked at the costumes the more he realized he didn't like any of the ones he was supposed to like.

Then he'd asked Adora if she could go as Fred and he could go as Daphne. It's a silly idea and it's half-formed when he suggests it, but

Adora runs with it. She's all enthusiasm when they go and pick out some clothes for their costumes.

He stuffs himself in the bathroom with the items they'd bought the day before. Scorpia's at practice and their parents are still at work so he has the house to himself.

He touches the fabric of the dress. It's purple and soft~~he~~ isn't sure he has clothes this soft. No wonder women like dresses. He turns away from the mirror, stripping quickly and then sliding the dress on. It rolls over his skin, clinging in a way that his cotton shirts and rough jeans don't.

He moves it until it feels like it fits right, turning it a little so it all lines up. He closes his eyes and turns to the mirror. When he opens them, he feels a well of disappointment.

He looks like a dude in a dress. He stares at the way it feels unflattering and he *hates* that. If only his body was different, maybe it wouldn't feel so awful and boxy. He tips his head to one side and the other.

Objectively speaking, he has a good face, maybe. He has a sharp nose, big eyes, white teeth and fangs. If he was a girl, maybe he would be pretty.

His breathing is shallow, and he realizes he's crying. It's stupid to think that this piece of fabric would change anything, on the inside or the outside. But he wants to change so badly. He hates feeling like this.

He stares in the mirror, his tears blurring his reflection. ~~I'm~~"~~he~~ takes a deep breath. "C'mon you fucking coward." He mutters to himself gripping the side of the sink for all its worth.

"I'm a girl."

The words don't tilt the world on its axis but the sigh that she releases might break her in half. The idea had been swirling in the periphery, nestled deep inside her as she lived her life, but it was never safe enough to think it, especially not at Weaver's.

But now it feels undeniable, like a piece of truth that was hidden beneath murky glass. She doesn't know what the fuck she's going to do about it but fuck she *knows* it.

She hears the door slam and she startles. It must be Scorpia from practice. She hurries to take off the dress, shoving it into the bag she bought it in and quickly putting on her clothes. They feel too baggy and coarse on her skin and fur.

She slips the dress under her bed. She decides that wearing it in public in front of everyone will be too much. She texts Adora.

The dress was a stupid idea. I'll go as Shaggy instead.

The next year she gets herself a cupcake when the 28th of October rolls around. It's frilly and pink, not because she likes that necessarily but because it feels symbolic. In a lot of ways, it feels like her real birthday, that other one she used to celebrate doesn't feel the same now that she knows who she is.

Adora is her college roommate now and freshman year has kept the blonde more overcommitted than ever between sports and classes. She's thought about coming out a million times but no one moment feels like the right one.

She looks down at the cupcake a strange mixture of excitement and sadness pitching together and rolling about her chest.

"Happy birthday, I guess. It's been a year—maybe next year things will be better." She closes her eyes and laughs a little when she thinks about wishing for boobs before blowing out her candle.

She startles when she hears the door to the kitchen open. Adora is sweaty from practice, her hair pressed against her forehead. "Why are you eating a cupcake without me? I thought we were friends!" Adora looks like she's joking but also like she isn't, eyeing the cupcake enviously.

She practically shoves the thing out of her own hand. "It's~~It's~~ nothing um." She tries to think of anything to say as Adora furrows her brow, looking between the candle and her panic-stricken face.

"What's wrong?" Adora is all soft and concerned and she feels like she's back at Weaver's, Adora reaching out with tenderness as she cries under her own bed.

"It's my birthday." She finally decides to say. It's a terrible way to start this but she doesn't know how else to. She hasn't told anyone and it's been a year. The truth feels like it's leeching out of her like people should just see that she's a woman but they don't, and it hurts worse than before when she was just confused about what it all meant.

"I'm pretty sure I know your birthday," Adora says, her head tilting as she looks at her.

"No, ~~I~~last year today I figured out something important about myself." She swallows hard. "I'm a girl." She admits.

She's said it to herself in the quiet of her room, affirming what she knows, but she's never said the words to another soul. No one is as important to her as Adora and she desperately hopes that she'll care about her anyway, even if she isn't who Adora thought she was.

Adora looks shocked her eyes flying over the other woman's face, probably hoping to find something she's missed. Maybe trying to find some sign of her girlhood.

Adora's face softens, and she steps closer, pulling her into a hug. "No matter what, you'll always be my best friend." She whispers

furiously. "You're amazing and I love you. Thank you for trusting me with this."

She cries in relief, a heavy weight she's been carrying lifted. Adora pushes the hair out of her eyes, cupping her cheek gently. Her ears twitch at the sensation and as if on cue Adora looks at them with big shining eyes.

"You're so cute," Adora says and her ears twitch without permission again. "Is that why your voice has been changing?" She asks quietly, not pulling away from the hug.

She nods shyly, letting herself stay curled under Adora's chin. "I started voice training recently. I've been on hormones since we started college, so not long at all. I'm still flat as a board." She grumbles. She's honestly surprised Adora picked up on the difference in her voice at all.

"Well, no matter what you can count on me for anything, okay?" She says seriously, looking like she's taking notes for a group project in her head.

"Thanks, Adora."

"What can I call you? She/her pronouns are good? Oh, shit have I done anything unaffirming I'm sorry I'll—"

"Dr, take it down like twenty levels." She says with a chuckle. "Um, I've been using Cassidy in my head." She watches Adora wrinkle her nose. "I know it's not the right fit, but it's for now until I come up with something better."

Adora looks horrified. "No, I mean if that's your name I support it I didn't mean anything or think anything—"

"Dr!" She looks up and Adora's hands are around her back, holding her closer. She can see almost every individual lash even though

they're blonde. "It won't be my real name or whatever I just like it better than the one you'd been using."

Adora nods, one hand reaching up to rub her ears. "Can I say something without it being weird?" She nods, eyeing Adora curiously. "I kind of suspected." She admits.

"Wait, really?"

"Cat. Can I call you Cat?" Adora checks that the nickname is still fine. She nods. "You have more bras than I do." She says softly with a knowing stare.

She flushes at the accurate assessment~~so~~metimes she wears them under baggy clothes or to sleep. "Well ~~th~~ey make me feel good!"

"And that's great. But kind of tipped me of f. And those heels hiding in your closet." Adora teases, eyes bright with a cocky smile.

She pretends to make a big deal of it, smacking the blonde with her tail but she's relieved by the teasing ~~it's~~ how she knows she and Adora are going to be okay.

By sophomore year, Cat can't really go stealth anymore and it doesn't seem she wants to. Adora knows it's silly but watching her come into herself has been heartwarming, to say the least.

"So, are you finally bringing your girlfriend around so we can meet her?" Glimmer asks slyly as she robs Adora of her apple and takes a bite.

"She's not my girlfriend." She denies hotly , snatching the apple back.

"Oh, I'm sorry is she your soulmate?" She laughs in a way that tells Adora Glimmer thinks that's the case.

Adora pales. "No, she isn't." She says quietly.

Glimmer snaps her head back to look at Adora, regret etched in her features. "Oh. I'm sorry it's just the way you talk about her"—

"It's fine, Glim. I'll bring her to the social after the game this week." She mumbles looking down at her plate.

Glimmer reaches out grabbing her shoulder and squeezing it. "Hey." She says softly. "I really am sorry."

Adora waves her off. "You didn't know." She supposes that many of the people who meet her think she has a girlfriend from the way she talks about her best friend.

"So, you don't know your soulmate?"

"Um no." Adora has never met anyone with the name Catra before, but she also hasn't looked too hard. "I guess I'll find her when I find her."

At first, she dealt with the fact that she liked women but once she settled on that, realizing that it was okay, she'd been excited to maybe someday find her other half. But after her best friend, the person who knows her most in the world started transitioning it was hard to focus on any other girl.

She feels a bit like a creep sometimes when she really thinks about how attracted and in love she is with Cat. Adora is part of Cat's support system and yet she's busy thinking about holding her and being closer still. It feels greedy—she gets to be there to see her discover new things about herself, to learn what parts of being a woman resonate and which don't, to laugh with her, share secrets, sometimes sleep in the same bed—but it's never enough.

"Hmm okay. You call your roommate Cat?" Glimmer asks curiously.

"Yeah, but it's Caitlin." No one else calls her Cat and Adora feels a little possessive of it.

"Well, the team's dying to meet her." She assures with a soft smile. "I'll make sure everyone is on their best behavior." Glimmer switches gears, excitement on her face. "What are you doing to celebrate your birthday today?"

"Cat and I are going to a museum." Cat swears up and down that she knows Adora will enjoy it even though she isn't typically a museum person. The truth is, she'd do anything to go with Cat and watch her get excited about whatever is on display. It sounds like a phenomenal birthday even if the museum ends up boring her to tears.

"Sounds very cute." Adora doesn't miss the significant glance Glimmer ends her way. "I hope you two enjoy your not date."

Adora rolls her eyes. "We will."

By the time she gets home and showers, she can hear Cat getting ready in the next room over. She hurries to toss on the clothes Cat had picked out for her.

When she walks out to the common area, she feels the wind knocked out of her. Cat's wearing a dress and Adora's eyes can't help to trail down her figure. She's always been slight but the figure she cuts in the dress is something else. It's not even the way it looks though there's been this quiet contentment that has slotted in ever since she came out that fills Adora with happiness.

"You look gorgeous." She breathes out, hoping she isn't blushing too badly. She tries to shove the thought out of her head, that Cat is dressed up to celebrate her birthday, that this is *for* Adora. "Like, I think you might kill someone from how pretty you look tonight." Specifically Adora, but those details are neither here nor there.

She watches as Cat's tail slashes behind her and she clears her throat. "I know that you took the gender-af firming compliments thing to heart, but you don't have to pretend I'm some goddess from another planet."

Adora bites her lip thinking of all the things she could say—sometimes she thinks that it would be worth it to speak the unspoken into existence, to tell Cat how she feels. But the risk of losing her—or worse, getting to love her and then having to stand back whenever her soulmate comes into the picture—stops her.

Instead, Adora steps closer and reaches a hand out to touch one of the straps on the dress, fixing a twist on it. "All of my compliments are sincere." She says softly. "And I'm really excited for tonight."

Cat smiles softly, her split eyes shining as she takes a step closer and initiates a hug. Adora holds her back, rubbing her cheek to Cat's the way she'd done since they were kids.

"Happy birthday." She mumbles into Adora's shoulder. "Now stop being so sweet or you're going to make me smudge my eyeliner."

"You know your eyes are beautiful without it." She reminds.

"I know but I like it."

Adora nods with a smile. She personally would rather die than have a sharp pencil near her eyeballs, but she gets that she's in the minority there. She reaches out tentatively and grabs Cat's hand. It's soft in hers, not dried up from chlorine like Adora's.

"Ready to go?" She prompts.

Cat nods, brushing some of her hair out of her eyes. "Born ready, princess. Let's celebrate twenty in style."

It's odd, having more friends than just Adora. Even though it's been the case since she started college. Sometimes it's hard to believe that she has a group of people who not only accept her but actively want to be part of her life.

The weirdest of those friendships is the one she has with Glimmer. At first, she was kind of jealous of the tiny girl, if only because of the amount of time she spent with Adora at water polo games and practices. But after she met her, they clicked unexpectedly.

Now they are celebrating her twenty-first at a club and it's just as loud and disconcerting as she imagined it to be. Even with the ear mufflers on, the sound still feels like it's rattling her skull.

"So, what even is your soulmate's name?" Glimmer asks out of the blue as they wait for their drinks.

Her hand comes up to cup her side where it is as if Glimmer has x-ray vision and can see it. "How about its none of your business?" She retorts back. "Why? Hoping it would be you?" She flirts.

"Ugh, I dream no! I don't want to be your soulmate, gross!" Glimmer protests loudly but she's blushing so she'd call that win. She knows the shorter girl is happy with her own soulmate, an engineering major named Bow.

"Then why are you asking shit that's none of your business?"

She shrugs, her glittery top dropping little shiny speckles as she moves. "I just think it's weird that Adora doesn't know the name of your soulmate, that's all."

She freezes for a moment glancing over at where Adora is sitting, chatting happily with Bow. "Did she talk to you about that?" She whispers wearily.

Glimmer glances over at Adora and then back to her. "She might have mentioned it. She said she wanted to know but didn't know how

to ask you."

Her heart pounds in her ears. She's always avoided showing anyone her soulmate's name, especially Adora. She's traced the letters on her rib cage more times than she can count.

"So why are you asking me about it?"

"I worry about you two. Adora won't let me see hers either." Glimmer leans forward grabbing her arm. "I just seems like a lot of weird feelings around it."

"Well, sometimes when you're a foster kid, it's not easy having a soulmate." She says quietly, watching Glimmer strain closer to hear her over the music. "It's hard to think there's someone who's supposed to be a perfect match for you when you don't even have adults that give a shit."

"Oh."

"Yeah. *Oh*, sparkles." She rolls her eyes. "Look I don't want to poke that bear if I don't have to. Besides my soulmate and I probably might never meet." She outright lies.

"Well, it'll be harder if you can't have more of us looking out for them you know?" Glimmer then eyes her. "Her? Him?"

"It's not like your soulmate's name comes with pronouns."

She rolls her eyes. "Ugh, you know what I mean."

"Not telling." She says flatly. "Thanks for playing though."

"Fine, you two be all weird and shit. I'm buying you another shot. I don't care how high magicat tolerance is, we're getting you trashed tonight."

Glimmer grabs the shot glasses from the bartender and shoves some her way, signaling for them to go back to their table where Bow

and Adora are waiting.

Holding Cat close never fails to make Adora's heart feel like it will grow wings and take flight. Even before she transitioned, Adora loved holding her friend close. Now though, it's an experience that is equal parts lovely and frustrating.

Cat's shirt has ridden up and besides avoiding looking because it's the decent person thing to do, she also doesn't want to give herself away. Cat's head is laying on her head, and she can probably pick up the way that her heart speeds up whenever she looks at her splayed on top of Adora like this.

"Cat."She murmurs softly . Adora isnt even sure what she wants to say she just needs to say something to break the soft silence of the morning. It's Adora's twenty-second, and Cat snuck into her room to wish her a happy birthday.

For the longest time, they couldn't really cuddle like this. Weaver kept them apart, saying boys and girls shouldn't show affection this way. Now it's a small piece of their childhood they could have again, defying Weaver, but more importantly doing what they want with no consequences.

Adora watches her tail twitch in amusement. "I can't believe you still call me that sometimes."She stretches and Adora's grip tightens a fraction.

It's an old nickname, one that Adora had taken to calling her when they were kids and Adora didn't have a great grasp on why her best friend had large soft ears and a tail. For a while, she used it until Weaver banned it and after Cat came out it felt a little like reclaiming it to use it openly.

"Does it bother you?"She says worriedly . She knows Cat has given her the okay before, but she'd hate to do anything that makes her feel bad.

"No, no. It's nice. In a lot of ways, it's the only name I've always had that doesn't make me feel dysphoric as fuck." She hums. "Also, Cat is a normal nickname for Katherine so you could probably use it in public without getting weird looks."

Katherine had been the name Cat was trying out recently and although she's already told Adora that it isn't quite right, she doesn't have any other ideas yet. Adora relaxes a little, allowing herself to melt further into the embrace. "Good, good." She can't deny, at least to herself, that one of the reasons she likes calling her Cat so much is because it's so close to her soulmate's name. As twisted as it might be, some part of her thinks of Cat as Catra, even though there's nothing to indicate that she is.

She runs a hand down her best friend's side, taking advantage of the way her shirt rode up to pet her there. Suddenly, Cat tenses, her tail fluffing up in a way that used to tell Adora she might get clawed. She looks down at Cat warily.

"No, you just—you touched it." She says gently, eyes darting away in embarrassment.

Adora drops her hand as if she's been burned. She doesn't need her to elaborate further to know what she's stumbled on. The name of whatever lucky girl will get to call Cat hers forever. She bites her lip to keep from asking if she'd ever thought about the name Catra.

Every time Cat tried a new name it felt like it was getting closer and closer—Cassidy, Caitlin, Katherine—and her heart dropped every time Cat tried on another name that wasn't the one embossed on her shoulder.

She shakes her head and continues petting, this time moving one of her hands up onto Cat's ears to rub them. It doesn't matter what name Cat picks ultimately if she's meant to be with someone else. She's not Cat's soulmate, the woman would have said something by now if she was.

"Do you ever wonder how your name appears on your soulmate's body?" Adora asks. They aren't really celebrating because she doesn't really feel connected to this birthday anymore, but Adora insists on at least spending time together, even if it's just studying.

She frowns, looking up from her notes. "What do you mean?"

Adora eyes her cautiously. "Well, you're still deciding your name. Does it change every time? Or what?"

She thinks about it, pursing her lip. "Not sure it matters." In all likelihood, her name isn't on anyone whatever it might be. Weaver was right when she said that she wasn't made to be with anyone else, just not for the reasons Weaver thought.

She puts down her pen. "I think it does. What if they meet you but they can't tell it's you." Adora sounds distressed by the possibility.

"Well, then fate is pretty shit isn't it." She runs her hands over her rib where she knows Adora's name rests. What a joke.

"You deserve your soulmate. Whoever they are." She says softly.

She swallows the lump in her throat. "Thanks. You do too. Or."

She thinks about asking about Adora's soulmate. She knows that her best friend has accepted her sexuality, but every time it looks like she might ask her, Adora looks anxious. And honestly, she's not sure she wants to know really.

"Look, it's the universe's plan or whatever mystical crap they say. It'll work out." She gives Adora a reassuring smile even though her heart hurts. Adora is kind and good—she can't tell her that whatever plans the universe has for Adora will leave her on the outside looking in.

She'd been thinking about it for a few weeks, but she thinks her real twenty-second birthday, four years after she came out to herself, is

the right moment to test out the new name.

"I've been thinking of a new name. I think it'll fit. But you can't laugh at it." She warns. She knows the name is a bit punny , but it's the first one that's really felt like hers since she started looking. "Catra." She says finally.

Adora stares at her for a moment before she starts crying. "C—Catra?" She whispers out her voice sounding beyond shocked.

Her eyes fly open in alarm. "Y es. Adora are you okay? Y ou can't hate it that much can you?" She isn't sure what to make of Adora's outsized reaction. She thinks this might be it—the name she'd been looking for—but if Adora hates it like this she doesn't know what she'll do.

Adora shakes her head quickly tears still streaming down her face. "Catra, no that's not it." She says finally between ragged breaths.

She feels warm hearing Adora call her this name, even with tears in her voice. "Then why are you upset?" She asks finally .

Adora tugs on her shirt and it's off and she's half naked. Before Catra can process any of that, she turns and then Catra sees it. There, on Adora's back is her name, the one she just picked for herself, sloping in gorgeous letters over her shoulder blade.

Her breath just kind of stops for a moment. She forgets it's important. Really, she forgets anything is important except Adora having *her* name on her back.

Adora turns her head, and she locks eyes with Catra. She looks so vulnerable, not only because her back is exposed but because of the timid look on her face. Catra can't help it she reaches up and touches the letters to make sure they are real. Adora lets out a surprised gasp that makes Catra pull her hand back.

"Did I hurt you?" Catra asks worriedly .

Adora pulls her shirt back on and turns around. "No, it just felt good."

Catra thinks to all the times the skin on her ribs tingled whenever Adora brushed over it. She tugs on her own shirt only raising it enough for Adora to see the side of her torso where her name lived.

"Look Adora." She moves her hand through her fur so Adora can see her name on Catra. Her eyes bug out and she starts crying again. She then tackles Catra onto the bed, pulling her close.

Catra holds her back just as tight. "Does this mean..." She trails off, afraid to bring to life the words that would change everything.

"It has to, doesn't it?" Adora looks so happy and Catra can't help but smile back. Then Adora smacks her. "I can't believe you didn't tell me that I'm your soulmate."

Catra's heart thuds loudly at words she hasn't let herself even think since she was sixteen. "I hadn't come out then, even to myself. Hadn't even thought about transitioning. And when you said your soulmate might be a girl..."

"You thought it couldn't be you." Adora realizes slowly.

"Yeah. I thought the universe had played a big cosmic joke on me. Letting my best friend and the most gorgeous girl I know be my soulmate, but then, it didn't matter because I wasn't yours."

"Cat." She says softly, the childhood nickname rolling off her tongue. "It was always going to be you I think."

Catra shakes her head, but her smile makes her cheeks hurt. "Adora, come on."

"Seriously! How could there be anyone else?" She asks softly, her face pressed to the side of Catra's neck. "I love you. A part of me always

has. And you know what this means right? Y ou were always Catra from the start."

Her heart swells and she tries to tamp it down a little. "No way ." Catra shakes her head, tears streaming down her face. "What if this isn't really my name? And it's j ust a coincidence that I picked it and now I've somehow messed up the universe or something."She's babbling nonsense but she's afraid of letting herself believe that she gets to have this.

Adora smiles softly. "I f this is the universe messed up, I don't want it to right itself."She gets closer and she's a hair breath away . Catra can hear more than feel the way her tail thumps against the mattress. "Can I kiss you"?

Catra breathes in sharply looking up at Adora with wide eyes. "I've only thought about that every day since I was fourteen."She says evenly.

Adora laughs and cups her cheek. Catra winds her tail around Adora's thigh to keep her in place. She leans forward and their foreheads touch.

"Y ou don't have to j ust think about it ever again."Adora promises, her blue eyes dark and her breathing deep as she leans forward and seals their lips together.

End Notes

This is my first time writing trans Catra and Ifeel pretty happy with it. Let me know what you think!

Kudos and comments make me a happy clam Iread every single comment and endlessly appreciate them. Also, you can follow me on Tumblr @ResFlower and Twitter @ResFlower1.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!